

New Years 2011 – Weaver's Needle & Superstition

December 31st to January 2nd
Superstition Wilderness, Arizona
Weaver's Needle (4,553')
Superstition Mountains (5,057')



Due to the seemingly unending Boise project hitting a critical phase I was unable to make use of my saved vacation days around Christmas. I was offered the chance to extend my New Year's holiday as compensation which of course had me instantly looking towards the wilderness and rubbing my hand in anticipation.

Originally I had visions of a big bang 5 day peak bagging extravaganza with long drives and longer days in between hitting all the 3rd class DPS peaks I could manage out towards Vegas starting with a crampon climb of Charleston. Then I realized I'd probably be out there for 5 days alone and started looking for things other people might actually want to join me on.

Then Jack Kieffer signed on willing to climb almost anything.

Well, I couldn't let that offer go.

So that left me digging through the Desert Peaks Section peak list looking for something interesting. After Jack and I climbed the 6th class Picacho a few weeks ago and found it easier than expected I was up for something challenging.

Weaver's Needle popped out at me as I'd heard of it run as an E level (4th class) provisional trip before.

A quick search on Google turned up the following:



This was something I had to climb.

Now we just had to decide if we wanted to do the 4th class (if you fall you die) or 5th class (oh my god I'm using a rope and why is this rock so crappy I can't place any protection but hey at least they can get my body back easily.)

After consulting with Jack it was decided we'd do the harder of the two routes which meant we were looking at a 5.6 or 5.3 route which would be a good opportunity to do a mini trad (placing gear in the rocks as you climb and clipping the rope in vs having bolts) lead.

(Actually, I sent Jack and peak guide and then asked which he wanted to do and he responded that he figured if it was a Matthew Hengst trip he didn't have any choice but to do the harder version. Gotta love Jack)

I flew home from Boise late the night before and with the usual post-arrival tasks I think I made it to bed sometime around 2:30 am December 31st. Bleh.

3:45 am on New Year's Eve I rolled out of bed and quickly threw everything into the back of my Rav4. I had two fellow climbers, Robert Neighbors and Jen Blackie, to pick up along the way and then we made it over to Jack's a bit before our 6 am deadline.

A short bit of chaos later we had everything transferred into the back of Jack's truck, topped off our coffee, and started the long drive out to Phoenix.

We had about 400 miles to cover and wanted to get out there early enough to do at least a warm-up hike to a local hieroglyph canyon if not get Superstition Mountain itself out of the way early.



We traded off driving with Jack taking us as far as San Jacinto where I took over for the remainder.

It took about 6 hours to drive out to Phoenix and we stopped for a quick lunch before continuing on out east to the boonies. A slight complication ended with us running inside the Arizona Mills Mall to grab food at Paradise Bakery.



Note the people in the background wearing shorts and flip flops while it's <40 degrees and windy outside. My theory is they actually live in the mall and hadn't been outside since summer.

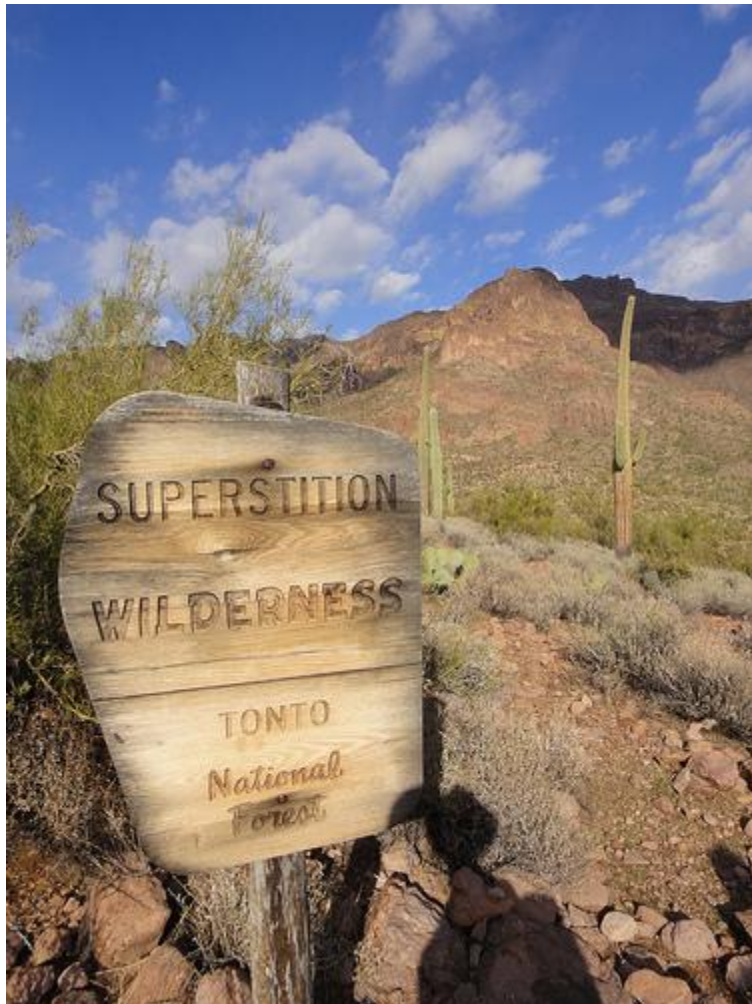
Another hour down the road and we pulled into the trailhead for Hieroglyph Canyon which is used by DPS as Superstition Mountains Route A.



It was 2 pm and there were several cars in the parking lot.



As we started up the trail we ran into multiple groups hiking out most of which were families or couples showing obvious effort being put into the relatively tame trail.





The most striking feature of the area was the very large cactus growing all around. Robert helpfully informed us these were Saguaro cactus.



They also had a large number of holes at roughly person height. Personally I think many of these were bullet holes. Once you get away from the heavy use trails they seem to disappear and the last day as we were hiking out we could hear a large amount of gunfire in the distance.



We started up the canyon proper the trail became a dry streambed that eventually led to an extremely pretty flowing creek.

The real reason we were out there that day was both to warm up and so see the allegedly amazing hieroglyphs which allegedly adorned the side walls of the canyon. The signs at the trailhead talked about them, the peak guide for the nearby Supersition talked about them, and out of the four of us not one was legally or functionally blind. You'd think we'd find these hieroglyphs quite easily.

Well, you'd be wrong.

Despite keeping our eyes open we apparently went right by them both on the way in and the way out. When we ran into a forest volunteer the second day he couldn't believe we hadn't seen them. I saw it's a story they put out to mess with the tourists.

We happily followed a series of clear ducks about 3.5 miles up the canyon just enjoying the scenery.





At this point we determined that we had beyond a shadow of a doubt passed the hieroglyphs and that we were still around 2,000 ft shy of Superstition peak. We made the call to turn back.



We made it about halfway back down the canyon before losing the light. Yet again out came the headlamps and we slowed things down quite a bit.



We made it out to the car around 7 pm and drove about 30 minutes out to the Peralta Trailhead which we'd be taking the following day to climb Weaver's Needle. There was a nearby campsite marked on the map which would be home sweet home for two nights.

The campsite was actually just an extremely unassuming turnoff that we drove by three times before determining that it was actually what we were looking for. It consisted of a short loop mostly cleared of rocks with no facilities but several established fire rings. And no other people.



It was New Years Eve and the wind made things quite chilly as Jack went to work on the fire and we layered on the warm clothing. Soon we had a satisfying blaze giving just enough warmth as we all huddled near.



Some of us were more aggressive in our fire-huddling than others.

We stayed up surprisingly late but the cold and the failing fire removed any inclination anyone may have had to wait out the new year and we went for our sleeping bags around 11:30 pm.

The next morning and one malfunctioning alarm clock later we were up and to the trailhead about an hour after dawn. Due to the time of year we only had about 10 hours of daylight and I wanted to make sure we had plenty of time to get up and down the technical rock sections before losing it.

We met the aforementioned volunteer at the trailhead who said another group was climbing Weaver's from the east side (easier and no ropes needed) and had left about 10 minutes before us. Bah, who wants to take the easy way?



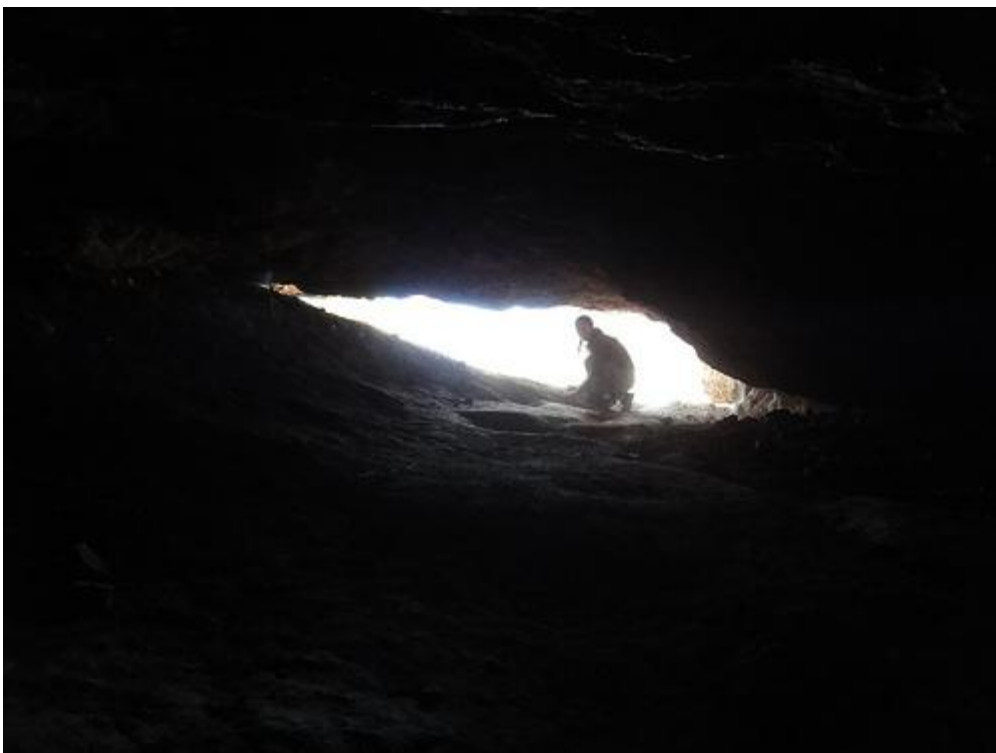
The route climbed to Fremont saddle before descending a canyon on the far side from which we'd approach Weavers. We hiked up a clearly marked trail gaining altitude steadily and remarking on the beautiful scenery.



Right before gaining the saddle we came across a hole in a rock. Having a healthy obsession with mines and caves I of course dropped my pack and dove inside.

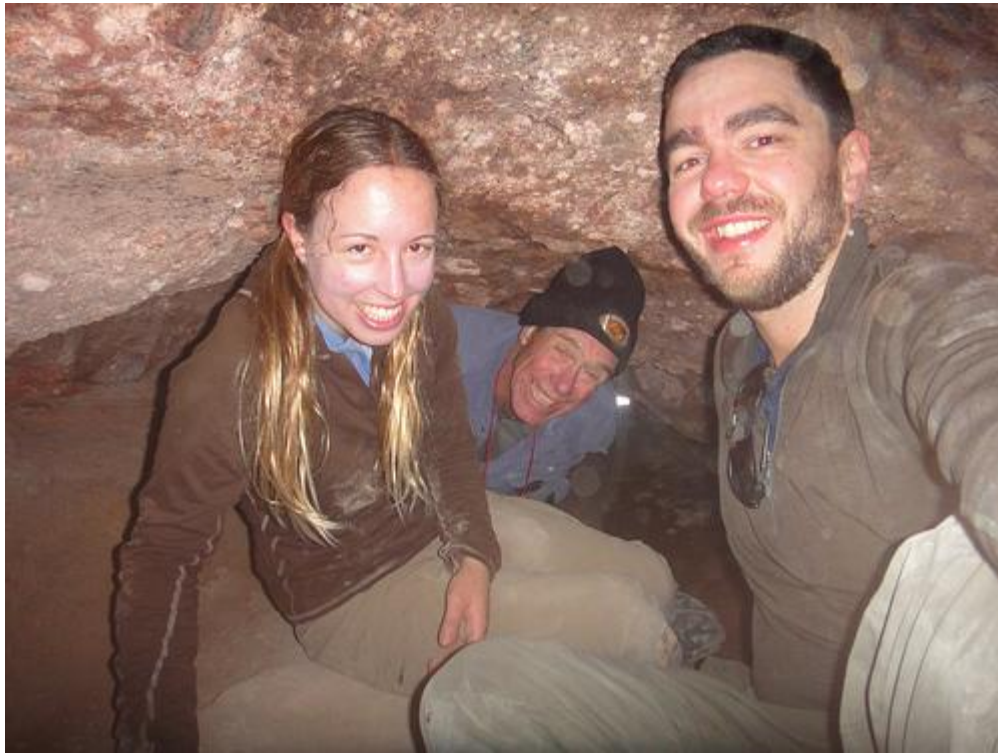


Jen followed me with almost as much enthusiasm...



...followed by Jack who was the only one patient enough to dig out his headlamp first.

Robert sat outside and shook his head at the crazy children in the cave.



We were able to go in a surprising distance (20+ feet) for a small hole beneath a rock before coming to a somewhat nasty pool of standing water. Outside it was windy and cold if one wasn't moving but after the first 10 feet or so I was sweating.

We took our picture, debated if it looked like the cave continued past the pool, and then reluctantly climbed back out into the cold to continue our journey.

Rejoining Robert we continued up the trail which now had a fair amount of ice in places which made footing rather treacherous. I elected to head off cross-country for the last bit.

Jen and I were in the lead as we came over the top of Freemont Saddle and got our first look at Weavers



The picture doesn't do it justice as in person it looked absolutely massive and much too close to be our goal.



Nevertheless it was soon clear that yes, we were going to climb that thing.

We quickly descended a surprisingly icy trail swinging around the west side of the needle.



Unfortunately at this point Robert informed us that he wasn't feeling up to attempting the peak. He had had knee surgery several months back and was worried about making it up and back down safely. He accompanied us to the base of Weaver's and then turned back to the cars.

And then there were three. The notch we were aiming for was quite clear and we just had to thread our way through a few rocks and climb a slope.

So, to maintain the difficulty level at this point I managed to take us a bit off course and swing around the north side of Weaver's amid some rock spires. This led to some exciting scrambling but I soon decided we should just swing back the way we came.

While scouting a way across Jen managed to deliver a rather solid blow to a cactus which had the unfortunate side effect of embedding a sizable cactus needle directly into her leg.

"Paging Doctor Hengst and Kieffer!"

After a few minutes of rooting around in her wound hole with Jack's first aid implements I managed to retrieve the rather sizable needle. Sadly I have no gory pictures to share as both hands were occupied and my camera batteries were running low due to the cold. I apologize. Someone really needs to buy me a GoPro...



After that diverting little endeavor we reversed course, swung back around south, and climbed the slope to the very obvious chute.



We were out of the sun as soon as we entered and it was noticeably colder than the slope below. We'd seen white patches from the distance we suspected were ice and that was soon confirmed though fortunately it was mostly confined to the rock faces off to the left. Mostly.



We picked our way gingerly over some initial ice covered rock while I kept looking above trying to get a feel for the technical section I knew I'd be leading.



And just as the peak guide described we soon found ourselves at a small vertical face with one obvious route up. Jen climbed up and eyeballed the last few moves which would have been trivial except for the fact all the footholds were covered in ice.

So instead she backed off, we put on our harnesses, helmets, and shoes, and I tied into one of the ropes and clambered up gingerly around the ice.

Sometime around here I was tied in and getting my shoes on when a loud noise had me on my feet in an instant. I looked around expecting to see a large boulder bouncing down the chute towards us but saw nothing. Soon some sizable chunks of ice crashed into view off to our left.

The ice deposits we'd seen on the side of the needle from below were warming in the sun and become dislodged. If they had been falling down the chute we would have been forced to turn around right there but fortunately our route was all in the shade. Still I tried to keep us moving as I didn't want to spend longer in the chute than I had to particularly as being tied to a rope my movement options were limited.



Climbed the first bit, set a simple belay, and quickly brought Jack and Jen up behind me.

Now we were looking at the real fun.

My pictures here are a bit lacking and actually mostly come from Jack's camera as my ongoing saga with the Sony batteries in my TX5 had left me all but out of juice.



According to the peak guide we'd find metal staked embedded into the rock which could be used to protect the route. I found the first stake and was surprised to find a brand new shiny climbing bolt driven into the rock right beside it. Jen climbed up next to me and set up to belay me from below.

From here things got interesting. I had three cams (#.75, #1 and #2) along and a set of BD nuts with the hope I'd be able to place them. The guide mentions there are supposed to be more stakes along the way which can be used as protection.

I climbed up without incident to a rather obvious belay station consisting of a flat ledge and a fairly sturdy looking piece of shrubbery. I set and anchor and brought up Jen and Jack again.

Again Jen set up a belay and I was off again.

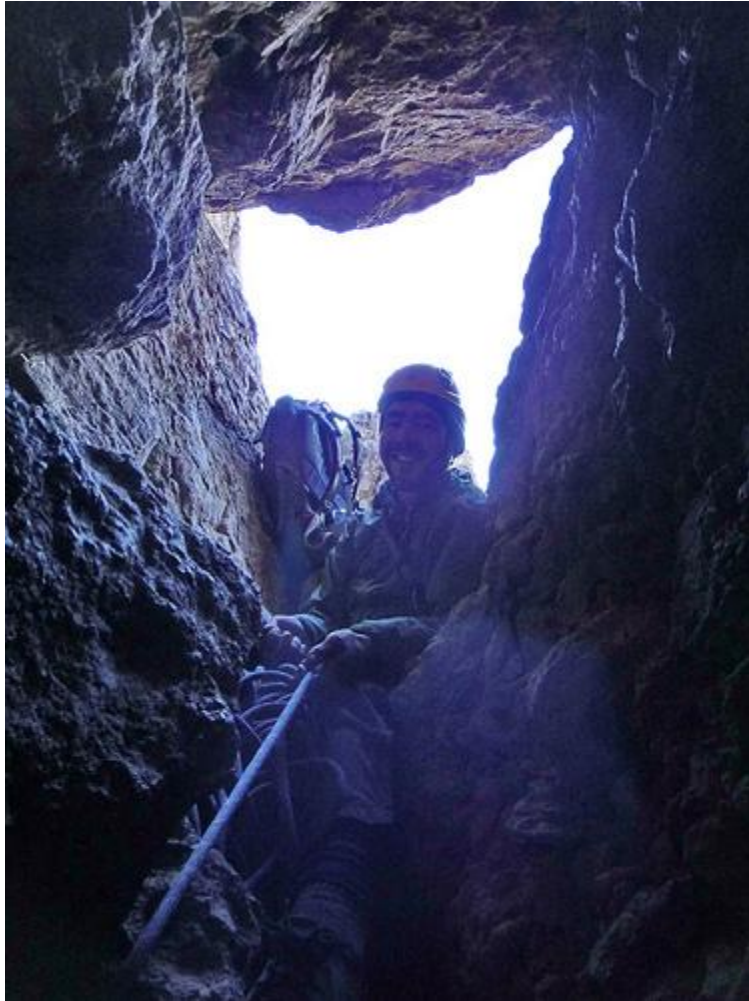


I didn't find any decent gear placements and after about 20 feet I was told by my belayer to place something now because I was making her nervous.

I settled for a bad placement of the #.75 yelling back down to Jen that she wasn't going to be happy with me. Soon after I found a much more solid placement (eg it might actually hold me if I fell) of the #1 inside the crack. That brought me below the chock rock only a few feet above a piece of protection.

According to the peak guide this area was the crux involving some 5.6 climbing but the face moves involved could be protected with another metal stake driven into the rock. Sounds great and all but I got up there and found no stake and no options for placing protection.

I was about to do something rather vertical and unprotected when I caught sight light coming from under the chock rock to my left. Gingerly moving that direction I found there was a gap underneath the chockstone and went for it.



It was a glorious hole which got me off the rock and into a secure place I could belay. It was also very very cold particularly as my belay position had me quite close and personal with a large amount of rock.

Sadly my camera battery died at this point so we didn't manage to get a picture of Jack climbing the pitch from above. Ah well, I'll have to get that during my 2x through the list.

Soon all three of us were safely through the hole and standing on the notch between the higher and lower bumps of Weaver's Needle. Poking around I found a shiny new belay station around the side of the chockstone giving us a clear path down. Looking down the opposite easier approach both Jen and I commented it looked rather vertical from where we were.

The route up the higher bump from the notch was advertised as 4th class but not requiring a rope (well, for most people anyway)

We brought a rope just in case and climbed up an awkward 3rd+ class segment followed by an easier 2nd class scramble.



From here we swung out onto the eastern face which wasn't difficult if you could ignore the fact that a fall would send you spilling off the side of the needle.

On the plus side body recovery would have been greatly simplified. (I didn't share this thought.)



And soon we were up top.

Victory! Time to strike a pose!



Or two

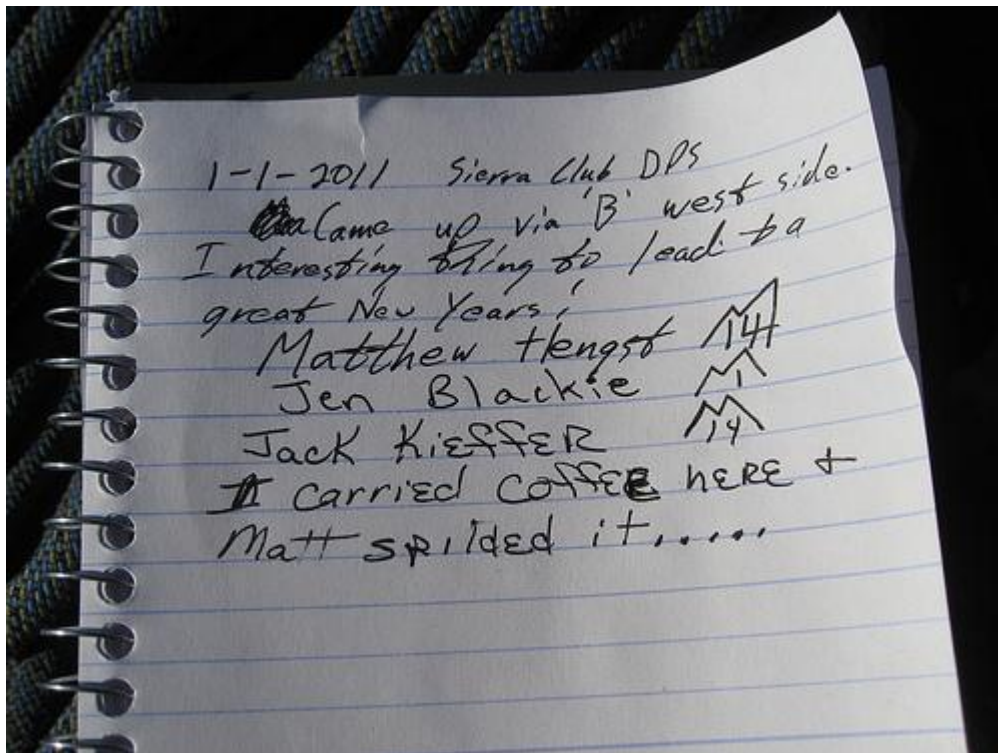


Or more





Then...tragedy!



Jack managed to restrain himself from bodily throwing myself off of the side of the peak over the loss of his coffee and we spent a good amount of time up there soaking in our victory. By then it was getting to 3 pm and we needed to be heading down as I wanted us off the technical rock before dark.



The descent to the notch wasn't bad though now of course we were staring down the drop during the 4th class section. We took our time and actually did use the rope briefly to get around down climbing that last awkward 3+ bit above the notch. Then we were back to the notch where we grabbed our other rope and set up the rappel.

This was greatly simplified by the existence of the premade anchor. We just had to tie the ropes together, thread them through the ring on the anchor, then toss the ropes down. Granted the ropes got caught up in the crack below but I just managed those as I went down.

I went down first, followed by Jack and Jen.



The initial section involved rappelling over an overhang which just takes a bit of care so ones face doesn't come into direct and enthusiastic contact with the rock but no one had any trouble.

We made it down, took off our gear, and put away the ropes as we started losing light. We could hear another group somewhere below making somewhat indistinct comments about seeing us rappelling down the chute but we never caught sight of them beyond headlamps in the distance. We had to gingerly down climb those last icy friction slabs but we made it to the solid slope below before we had to put on our headlamps.

The next several hours were spent hiking out in the dark watching the trail beneath our feet carefully so we didn't hit an icy patch and go flying. Eventually we approached the trailhead though the last section we ended up inadvertently bushwhacking after losing the ducks in the dark.

The sight of Jack's truck's headlights guided us in as Robert had seen our approach. After taking his time to get out he had waited in the much warmer vehicle and napped a bit until we rejoined him.

Back at the still chilly campsite we started a fire with the remainder of our wood. Lack of sleep and being rather sick had caught up with me at that point and despite my desire to stay up for a while and enjoy the fire I soon had to admit defeat and crawl into my sleeping bag as I was literally falling asleep on my feet.



Sunday we had one more peak to do and then the 6-ish hour drive back home. We mutually decided we didn't really need a pre-dawn start and woke up with the sun and got ready.

The goal was to do Superstition by the B route which could be accessed off the same road we were camping off of.



After a slight bit of confusion we decided the blocked off road near our camp the previous night was in fact the road leading to the trailhead. Extra mileage for us!

Robert declined to subject his knees to the abuse the 3300 ft of gain would inflict and stayed behind to do his own explorations.

Jack, Jen, and I once again set off up a clearly marked trail.



After climbing up and over a ridge we caught sight of Superstition off in the distance.



From the peak guide we were expecting to have to exit the trail at some point and climb to the ridge cross country but instead we found the trail went all the way to and past the summit.

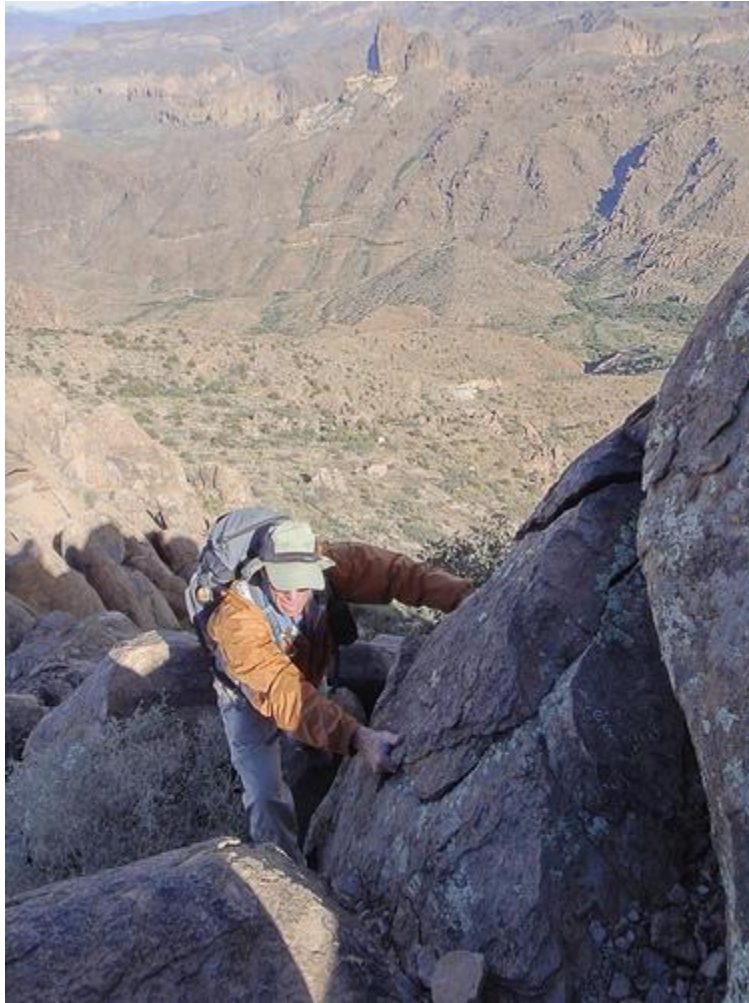




When we reached the summit area itself we continued to the far side in the hopes of hiking over and entire thing. Instead we found the far side was a bit on the impassable side. At this point we probably should have just swung back the way we came and took what would surely be an easy and clear trail to the summit.

...yea...

...so instead we took a bit more direct route. After a few false starts and one bush that will never be the same we found something that wasn't too questionable. Straight up the rocks, through a bush, across a spine, then a lieback move to gain the summit itself. All while a local group below watched us, shook their heads, and proceeded to stroll up the standard way.



Jack follows me up with his usual uncomplaining enthusiasm.



We made it up top to find a local meetup group of 12 hikers coming up the normal person route we'd ignored.



That did make it easy to pose for pictures.



We descended the boring normal way and returned along the same trail.



Jack wanted a picture of this cactus so I did my best to make the picture worthwhile.



As we came down the last slope we could hear gunfire in the stance. Lots of gunfire. At a minimum we could hear small arms, shotguns, and an automatic weapon.

We joked Robert seemed to be making a good final stand.

Robert met us where the trail crossed a fence line and we were all together again at last.



And now we faced a rather daunting 6+ hour drive home.



We stopped in Phoenix to get Mexican food and then drove towards the storm we heard was hitting LA.

We traded off driving home and after what seemed like a very very long time pulled into Jack's driveway.

And, just because the adventure couldn't be over too quickly it turned out my battery had gone dead due to leaving a light on in the cab. Oops.



Fortunately this was the perfect opportunity for Jack to use his handy dandy jump start / emergency light / device charger which made him extremely happy. I decided I'd let me battery go dead more often.

Two more down!